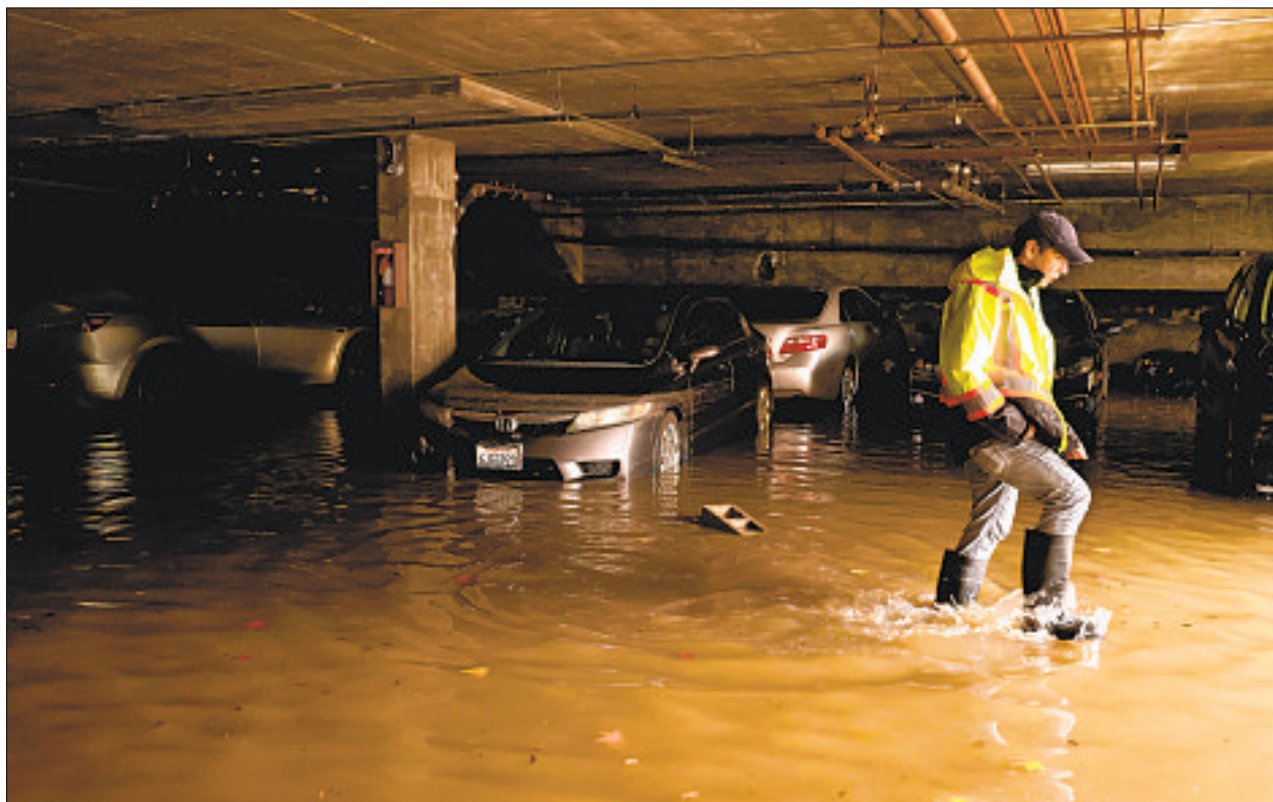




GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

### NO SHELTER FROM SOUTHLAND STORMS

Sergio Gutierrez wades in a Palms garage. This November is region’s wettest on record. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

## Empty reservoir not a key factor

The state cites water system limitations, not the drained container, in Palisades fire toll.

BY IAN JAMES

In January, when crews fighting the fast-spreading Palisades fire were hampered by low water pressure and dry hydrants, Gov. Gavin Newsom ordered an investigation. After a 10-month review,

California officials concluded in a report that the water supply in Southern California was “robust” at the time of the fire and that the water system isn’t designed to handle such large, intense wildfires.

The state’s findings, released Thursday, also address an issue that has been a point of frustration and anger among residents in Pacific Palisades: the fact that the Santa Ynez Reservoir, which can hold 117 million gallons of drinking water, was empty for repairs at

the time of the fire.

“Draining the Santa Ynez reservoir was necessary to protect public health while repairing the tear in its cover and required by both federal and state regulations,” the report says. Even if the reservoir had been full, the flow rate in the system’s pipes “would have been a limiting factor in maintaining pressure and the system would have been quickly overwhelmed” and hydrants would have lost pressure. The state’s findings are in line with what L.A. water of-

ficials have said about the reservoir, the water system and the factors that caused the loss of water pressure.

“The report confirms that the Santa Ynez Reservoir was offline to make necessary repairs and that issues with water pressure during the fire response were due to the extraordinary demand on the system, not because of inadequate water supply,” said Ellen Cheng, a spokesperson for the Los Angeles Department of Water and Power.

[See **Water**, A9]

## Trump lawsuit puts college dreams at risk

Justice Dept. alleges in-state aid programs for undocumented students are illegal.

BY JAWEED KALEEM

Born in Mexico and brought to the U.S. by her parents when she was 1, Sara has lived in California nearly all her life. As an undocumented immigrant, she pays in-state tuition rates at East Los Angeles College — \$619 per semester, a fraction of the \$5,286 charged to out-of-state students.

Because of her immigration status, Sara is not eligible for Pell Grants and other federal student aid. But under a 2001 state law and the California Dream Act — Sara pays lower in-state tuition and receives state financial aid for college — she has been able to afford her education. When she receives her associate’s degree, she intends to transfer to a Cal State or UC campus and major in business administration.

But Friday her dreams felt more out of reach, after the Trump administration sued California, alleging the state’s laws granting in-state tuition rates and financial aid to undocumented students are illegal. The suit threatens the higher education goals of about 80,000 undocumented college students, many who arrived in

the state as children.

“After I get my degree, I want to use it to work in California and contribute to my community,” said Sara, who requested to withhold her last name because she is fearful of federal immigration enforcement action. “How does that hurt anyone?”

The Department of Justice on Thursday sued California and its three public university systems, seeking to overturn a decades-old state law that provides lower in-state tuition to undocumented students who have attended the state’s high schools. The Trump administration also sued to put an end to the California Dream Act, which it alleges gives illegal preference for financial aid to people who are not citizens.

The moves are the latest in a series of similar legal actions the federal government has taken this year against states including Texas, Kentucky, Illinois, Oklahoma and Minnesota.

U.S. Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi said the government took the action because California has a “flagrant disregard for federal law.”

State leaders disagreed, saying they will defend the laws.

“The DOJ has now filed three meritless, politically motivated lawsuits against California in a single week. Good luck, Trump. We’ll see you in court,” said Izzy Gar-

[See **College**, A7]

### ANALYSIS

## A pariah no more, he’s Trump’s pal

Saudi crown prince, whom CIA implicated in journalist’s death, is celebrated in D.C.

BY NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — Seven years ago, he was virtually persona non grata, any link to him considered kryptonite among U.S. political and business elite for his alleged role in the killing of a Washington Post columnist and Saudi critic.

But when Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman came to Washington this week, he cemented a remarkable comeback, positioning himself as the linchpin of a new regional order in the Middle East, and his country as an essential partner in America’s AI-driven future.

During what amounted to a state visit, the crown prince — Saudi Arabia’s de facto leader — was given the literal red carpet treatment: A Marine band, flag-bearing horsemen and a squadron of F-35s in the skies above; a black-tie dinner attended by a raft of business leaders in the prince’s honor; a U.S.-Saudi Investment Forum at

the Kennedy Center the next day.

Throughout, Bin Salman (or MBS, as many call him) proved himself a keen practitioner of the brand of transactional politics favored by President Trump.

He fulfilled Trump’s ask, first floated back in May during the Riyadh edition of the U.S.-Saudi Forum, to up the kingdom’s U.S. investment commitments from \$600 million to almost \$1 trillion.

And the prince managed to mollify Trump in his oft-repeated call for Saudi Arabia to join the Abraham Accords, the normalization pacts with Israel brokered during the president’s first term, even while changing nothing of his long-stated position: That establishing ties with Israel be accompanied by steps toward Palestinian statehood — an outcome many in Israel’s political class reject.

“We believe having a good relation with all Middle Eastern countries is a good thing, and we want to be part of the Abraham Accords. But we want also to be sure that we secure a clear path [to a] two-state solution,” Bin Salman said.

“We want peace with the Israelis. We want peace with

[See **Bin Salman**, A4]

## Joshua trees scorched during shutdown

In ‘nightmare scenario,’ fire wipes out hundreds of park’s namesake yuccas

By Lila Seidman



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

ONE OF MANY damaged Joshua trees dot Joshua Tree National Park after a 72-acre fire in October.

with the park, who also spoke on condition of anonymity for fear of retaliation. During the last government shutdown six years ago, the revelation that vandals appeared to have chopped down a few of the Dr. Seuss-esque trees grabbed national headlines. In this instance, the firefighter estimates more than a thousand trees were torched. Brendan Cummings, conservation director for the Center for Biological Diversity, also surveyed the plants in the burn zone and came up with a similar estimate.

The area, not far from Black Rock Campground, is one of the park’s densest Joshua tree woodlands. Perched at a higher elevation, it’s considered a climate refuge for the iconic

[See **Joshua Tree**, A9]

## Ukraine’s choice: A bad deal or U.S. support

BY ILLIA NOVIKOV AND BARRY HATTON

KYIV, Ukraine — Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky told his country in an address Friday that it could face a pivotal choice between standing up for its sovereign rights and preserving the American sup-

port it needs, as leaders discuss a U.S. peace proposal seen as favoring Russia.

Russian President Vladimir Putin, meanwhile, cautiously welcomed the U.S. plan to end Moscow’s nearly four-year war in Ukraine, which contains many of the Kremlin’s long-standing demands while offering limited security guarantees to

Ukraine. Putin said it “could form the basis of a final peace settlement,” while accusing Ukraine of opposing the plan and being unrealistic.

The plan foresees Ukraine handing over territory to Russia — something Kyiv has repeatedly ruled out — while reducing the size of its army and blocking

its coveted path to membership in the North Atlantic Treaty Organization.

Zelensky, in his address hours earlier, did not reject the plan outright, but insisted on fair treatment while pledging to “work calmly” with Washington and other partners in what he called “truly one of the

[See **Peace plan**, A4]

### Scores seized at school in Nigeria

Gunmen attack and abduct 215 pupils and 12 teachers at St. Mary’s School, a Catholic institution. **WORLD, A2**

### Swalwell enters race for governor

Longtime congressman declares bid during an appearance on Jimmy Kimmel’s late-night show. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

### Weather

Partly sunny, warmer. L.A. Basin: 74/50. **B3**



SAL VEDER Associated Press

### VIETNAM POW DIES

Col. Robert Stirm is greeted by family at Travis Air Force Base, Calif., upon his return in 1973, recorded in a Pulitzer-winning image. **NATION, A6**



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